reportage, it seemed to me that the reason the arguments received nationwide traction was due to my emphasis on the fundamental rights of the Deity as:

> 1. a ‘person’ within the meaning of Article 25(1) of the Constitution; and
> 2. the very fount of the religious practices observed by and in the Sabarimala Temple, which lent the temple a denominational/‘sampradayic’[2] character within the Dharmic fold under Article 26.

In my view, I presented a fairly clear, reasonable, and constitutionally rooted argument in support of the temple’s practice, especially on the rights of the Deity, which was the product of the creative and untiring efforts of a dedicated team that blended the religious with the constitutional. Till date, I stand by my legal submissions and see no reason to change my position whatsoever. I say this from a position of clarity and conviction, especially in light of the subsequent endorsement of the juristic character of a Deity by a Constitution Bench of the Supreme Court in the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi verdict delivered on 9 November 2019.[3]

Not surprisingly, given the breathless nature of the news cycle and the terminal decline of facts and nuance in public discourse, very few media outlets made an honest attempt to understand or unbundle that multilayered argument. Instead, sensationalism defined the headlines as well as the contents of news reports with few honourable exceptions. Public reactions to the arguments too were mostly in the extreme with almost no room for a middle ground, which perhaps says a lot about the times we live in than my own arguments. The more predictable jibes like ‘patriarchal’ and the like did not pique my attention much given the nature of the matter and the dramatis personae involved, apart from the sloganeering hue such words have acquired over the years instead of standing for the genuine concerns and issues they were meant to represent in the first place.

What I found most interesting was that those who disagreed with me used words, such as ‘orthodox’, ‘traditional’, ‘anti-rational’, and ‘anti-modern’, to caricature my position.[4] To be clear, I was intrigued not by the criticism itself, which was expected, but by the use of such words as pejoratives to criticise a position that supported a religious institution. After